



EIGHT

The Story of a Poem

Sushama is writing a poem. The first two lines form themselves very easily on a sheet of paper.

*A tear-drop sways my lashes
As I think of you – even now.*

These are very ordinary lines that can be written by any romantic or postmodern poet. If they deserve any special attention, it is only because they are written by a woman. You know, our society, which incidentally includes Sushama's husband Reghuraman too, always goes out of the way to find out the latent autobiographical content in women's writing. If Reghuraman reads these lines, he will certainly look at Sushama with suspicion, for he is very particular that his wife, like Caesar's, should be above doubt.

Sushama's poems are thus born in a hostile and suspicious world. Look at her, writing the poem at the kitchen table on which lie scattered some blank sheets of paper, a broken pencil, a knife, vegetables sliced and otherwise, and a few plates. The rings of lady's finger may be for frying or for making a *kichadi*¹. The unripe bananas, drumsticks, tomatoes, etc., foretell the possibility

¹ A dish made with curd and cucumber/lady's finger

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of an aviyal. Sushama, just watch her. She leaves the vegetables on the table, half of them sliced, to write the first two lines of the poem. She then leaves the poem, two lines written, to come back to the vegetables. Now she has sliced an entire lot of lady's finger into beautiful rings. Her lips are mumbling something inaudible as she puts them away and turns to the unripe banana. See her peel them easily with the tip of her knife. Suddenly she stops and picks up the pencil, and we see four lines of the poem being born effortlessly:

I remember –

how we walked huddled under an umbrella,

how the torrential downpour drenched the lonely street,

how you put your hand on my left shoulder,

how my whole body shivered at your touch,

Sushama's eyes brighten up very slowly. The movements of her hands slow down as if she is falling asleep. She is going off—into another world that has rain and electric fingertips. Let us leave her there and go meet Reghuraman.

Reghuraman stands at the bus-stop waiting for the bus to take him to office. Usually he rides a bike, but today the bike had refused to move. So he has dropped the children at school in an auto-rickshaw and now waits at the bus-stop. The bus must come soon, for Reghuraman has to reach his office before the red question mark appears against his name in the attendance register.

Reghuraman's seat in the office is near Shriranjini's. Reghuraman likes Shriranjini. He had fantasised on several parts of her body as belonging to Sushama; but strangely, he has never wished to have Shriranjini as his wife. As wife he prefers only a woman like Sushama, who is quiet, does not talk much, does all the chores without ever complaining and is excellent in the culinary arts. Shriranjini is good, but only as a friend. A good friend to talk

to when your mind is parched. Someone good enough to be taken to Indian Coffee House to argue over a cup of tea and masala dosa, about Borges or Aravindan or Deconstruction. If she objects not, he is willing to explore a bit further—but only up to the point from where he can turn and walk back. No, he would never wish to have Shriranjini as wife. Let feminists be the wives of other men.

As Reghuraman reflects thus on Shriranjini, a bus stops before him. Children in school-uniform clamber down leaving the bus almost empty. Reghuraman sits comfortably near a window and continues thinking of Shriranjini. Now he wishes she comes to office today clad in red silk. As he entertains these simple thoughts, the conversation of two self-styled critics from behind falls upon his ears.

A: Did you read E's latest story in the magazine?

B: Yes, I did. I think the unhappy wife in the story is the author herself.

A: I thought so too. But how can you say that for sure?

B: You see, a colleague of mine lives near her house. He told me that ... er ... there are certain problems in her marriage. Haven't you noticed—all her heroines go in for extramarital relations? They hate marriage.

A: You are absolutely right. So the affair of the girl in the story ...

B: ... is of course the author's.

Reghuraman who knows E, the author, and her happy marriage, listens with curiosity to the yarn of stories spun about her. He feels relieved that Sushama is not a writer. Or this crude society would have peeped into his bedroom too. Now people will only say that Reghuraman is a happily married man. He thanks his stars for saving him from being the husband of a writer.

Shriranjini writes poems in English and people do talk about her too. Why should all these women have the urge to write? He

has read Shriranjini's poem that won a prize from the British Council. It begins:

*Strip me
see the real me
with your naked eyes
And be frightened,
shocked,
morally decayed*

Who else but Shriranjini can write such beautiful lines? Strip me ...! What an interesting deconstruction it would lead to! Reghuraman ran his tongue over his lips.

Now there are three more lines in Sushama's poem. They are:

*how each rain-drop blossomed to a flower,
how fire burned in each of its petals,
how redness and warmth spread through the body,*

The incomplete poem rests on the dining table. Sushama, her chores over, is taking a shower. As water flows down her body we see that her mind is still dazed with the half-born poem. It is hot around the house, the sun burning in rage. Plants drop down their heads unable to bear the heat. But it rains where Sushama is. It rains in Sushama's mind. And one more line is born within her:

how your eyes were hid by my scattered tresses

And we see Sushama, naked, running to the dining table to add that line to the bottom of the poem—in a hurry to catch it before it vanishes. She scribbles it down without even bothering to notice if the curtains are drawn, or if her neighbour's eyes are preying around. As she writes, a little pool of water forms around her feet; she runs back to the shower shaking her dripping hair. As she does so, she catches a glimpse of herself in the bedroom mirror.

Once again she stands under the shower, now remembering Reghuraman's flippant remarks on her body. He had remarked to his colleagues who had come down to his house for tea, 'You see, there is only one difference between my wife and Miss Universe. The curves are in the right places on Miss Universe and in the wrong places on my wife.' He had laughed, enjoying his own joke, while his colleagues, evidently uncomfortable, had pretended to smile. Only one lady—a Shriranjini or so—had expressed her dislike. She had come to the kitchen later and had tried to comfort Sushama. 'Take it easy, Sushama. Reghuraman is really fond of you. He talks about you in the office at least one hundred times a day.'

Sushama, knowing fully well that if at all he talked about her it would only be in comparison with other women, had not asked for details. In fact, now she does not want the memory of that afternoon to intrude into her mind, occupied with poetry. 'Go away,' she tells that memory. 'Don't stand in the way of my poem. Get lost!'

Reghuraman comes from the canteen, his hands and breath smelling of chicken fry, and asks Shriranjini, 'Aren't you taking any food? Are you fasting today too?'

'Yes,' she tells him. 'Today is Thursday. I observe the *Santhana Gopala Vrata* for the benefit of my children.'

'What a combination of contradictions you are,' says Reghuraman. 'You hold such free and fearless opinions, but sometimes behave in a very conventional manner.'

When Shriranjini refuses to respond, he adds, 'But I must tell you that the paradox adds to your charm.'

To lure him away from the subject Shriranjini asks, 'Why can't you bring lunch from home? Sushama would prepare it happily for you.'

'I don't like cold food,' he says. 'I enjoy only hot or warm food. That was why I was particular about marrying an unemployed, unambitious girl. You know, there is no refrigerator in my house.'

Sushama tried her best to make me buy one, but I was firm not to. Now do you understand Shriranjini, the secret of my healthy body?’

Shriranjini’s eyes steal over to his strong hands and broad chest.

She withdraws her eyes guiltily, gets up and moves away, mumbling some excuse.

The poem now rests on Sushama’s lap. She has added a few more lines to it.

*how our paths forked in two different ways,
how our memories were blotted out by hands unseen,
I remember all these for ever and ever.*

Sushama reads the poem again and again, and makes more changes. Outside the house, the sun has started losing its rage. Sushama is very happy now. There is no trace of any fatigue, though she has risen with the sun and moved with it. There is a celestial rapture on her face as if she is an *apsara*² who has come to the green woods to give birth to a baby in secret. Her eyes rise from the poem and wander around the room, not seeing the snacks and the cup of tea kept on the table, or the time on the clock.

‘I’m leaving early,’ says Reghuraman to Shriranjini. ‘I will not come back as usual after dropping the children at home. I have to go to the workshop to see how my bike is. See you tomorrow.’

Shriranjini looks up from a file and gives him a smile.

He pauses at her table to whisper in a low tone, ‘Will you wear the red sari tomorrow? Please, it’s a request.’

He walks fast without waiting for a reply. Shriranjini looks with agitation at his receding figure. His firm footsteps seem to tread on her heart.

² Celestial nymph

Sushama's trembling hands are now dialling a telephone number. She cradles the poem on her lap like a baby. She has not added any line to it; so we can safely conclude that it is complete. After dialling the number Sushama sits back restlessly.

We can hear the faint ringing of a telephone somewhere far away. It stops; someone has picked up the receiver. We can hear a masculine voice say, 'Hello?'

Sushama's face tightens like a heart that is about to break. After a slight pause the voice asks again, 'Hello? Who is this please?'

Sushama suddenly replaces the receiver. Her pulse-rate slowly comes down to normal and her face relaxes. She is now adding a few more lines to the poem:

*Though you no longer hold me in your mind,
you are still the tear-drop on my lashes.
As each rain-drop falls from the sky,
you fill my thoughts like the waves of the sea.*

Reghuraman and the children have arrived in the auto-rickshaw. Sushama, hearing the sound, jumps up from her seat and tears the poem to small pieces. She throws them out of the window and rushes to the door to open it before the doorbell rings, for she is the ideal wife and the ideal mother.

Since Sushama has destroyed the paper, the readers who want to read the poem in full can pick up the verses scattered in this story, put them together and read.